Fran's Family — Party Packet (FINAL, merged Nov 2, 2026 — supersedes FINAL + Suz Q&A addendum as the single party document)

For: Eddie & Brenda Cogar surprise 50th anniversary — Sat Nov 7, 2026, 3–6pm, The Silo, 1135 Main Street, Granville, WV. Built from the record-by-record Ancestry rebuild (Nov 1–2), with Suz's live Q&A answers of Nov 2, 2026 (relayed by Dan) merged in. Status tags: [record] = primary record in hand · [family-confirmed] = confirmed from personal knowledge by Suz, who knew the people · [supported] = strongly supported by the records, not proven by a single document · [open] = unanswered. Hedges are kept exactly as given — please keep the wording honest if it comes up in conversation.

1 · The tree, one page

Fran's parents - Marion Edward Thomas Sr. — b. 28 Dec 1878 [record: his own WWI draft card, signed "Edward Marion Thomas"] — d. 30 Sep 1953 [record]. Farm manager on US 19, Maidsville; the 1940 census values the farmhouse at $5,000 and credits him a 5th-grade education and eight children raised in it. **- Ida Ellen Conwell** — 1880–1979 [record].

Their nine children [record: census households 1910–1950] 1. Mildred (~1905) · 2. Ruby E. (~1906) · 3. Mary P. (~1910) · 4. Clara L. (~1912) · 5. Dorotha M. (~1914) · 6. Edward M. (~1917) · 7. **Donald Elmore** (~1919–1994) · 8. **Fran** (1920–2018) · 9. **Juanita Elizabeth** (1924–2011) - The old family tree listed ten — Donald and Elmore were the same man, counted twice (one census used his first name, another his middle). Nine is right, and it matches Fran's obituary exactly: she was "the last living of 8 siblings." [record]

Fran — born **Jesse Francis Thomas**, 15 Aug 1920, Fort Martin, WV — d. 4 Apr 2018, Uniontown, PA [record/obit]. She later feminized the spelling to Frances — "Fran." Marriages: **(1) Emmet Graden Van Voorhis**, 12 Mar 1938, Frederick, MD [record: newspaper decree coverage + family scrapbook clipping] — divorced, grounds "indignities" · **(2) Thomas M. Whyel** · **(3) Ira Burdette Coldren Jr.** (15 Jun 1924 – 25 Aug 2008). Only child: **Rebecca Van Voorhis** — born with no middle name; she later added one and lived as **Rebecca Diane "Diane" Van Voorhis** [family knowledge + records]. Diane m. **George Dixon Shrum Jr., 8 Sep 1961, at 117 Belmont Circle** [record: marriage index] — the house that became Fran's home for ~57 years. Diane → **Suzanne Whyel Shrum Frank** ("Suz" — her middle name Whyel is Fran's second husband's name, carried into the next generation) → **Daniel Gillingham Frank** and Vanessa Frank.

Fran's third husband's family (built in the rebuild — Uniontown people, Fayette County) [record] John D. Coldren (1779–1842) → Ellis Coldren → John F. Coldren (1848–1920) → Ira W. Coldren → **Ira Burdette Coldren Sr.** m. **Eleanor Clarke Lincoln, 19 Oct 1922** [record: marriage index] → **Ira Jr.**, Fran's husband. Fran married into a Uniontown family rooted as deep as her own.

The Cogar branch — why the Thomases are at this party - Juanita Elizabeth Thomas (12 May 1924 – 30 Mar 2011, buried Fort Martin) [record], the baby of the nine. - 1950 census, Fairmont: Juanita is married to **Burdette A. Thomas**, working on high-beam headlights, with a one-year-old son, **Edward Thomas** (b. 13 Jun 1948) [record]. - 1958, Monongalia County: Juanita marries **Okey M. Cogar** [record: marriage index]. Edward, about ten, takes the Cogar name — the records pick him up as **Edward Thomas Cogar** of Maidsville, 1144 Fort Martin Road [record: public records], and a Brenda Cogar at that same address lists Edward and Okey among her relatives [public-record profile]. - **[family-confirmed — say it this way]** Eddie Cogar **is** Juanita's son Edward, from her first marriage — confirmed by **Suz, who knows Eddie and Brenda personally from years of family trips to West Virginia with Fran** for family gatherings. That is a lived relationship, not a paper inference. Keep the paper gap honest if it comes up: no single written record yet names Edward Cogar as Juanita's son, and Eddie & Brenda's marriage isn't verified in the records searched — Juanita's 2011 obituary is the document that could settle the paper side. - **Alan Cogar** — Eddie's brother, deceased [family-confirmed — Suz]. Suz thinks Alan was the younger brother but is **not sure** — keep that hedge. Alan rests entirely on Suz's testimony: a public-records search on Nov 2, 2026 found no obituary or record for him. (On how the boys came to the Cogar name: Suz first recalled thinking they "were adopted," then offered "or maybe a first marriage." The records say first marriage for Eddie — see the 1950 census above; if an adoption happened, it would have been Okey adopting the boys after the 1958 wedding. Unresolved — don't state either version as fact.)

Fran's deeper lines — where each one honestly stops - Thomas: Hezekiah Thomas (d. 19 Feb 1900, age given as 103) + Abigail Tibbs. The next document — the original 1829 Monongalia marriage bond — isn't digitized anywhere. [record wall] - **Sarah Catherine, Fran's grandmother — the rebuild's biggest correction:** she was **born a Sarver, not a Bright.** Her own WV death certificate names her parents **Harry Sarver + Kathryn Potts** of Pennsylvania; she was b. 13 Mar 1856, d. 15 Jan 1923, buried Mt. Union, and she married Robert M. Thomas in 1875 as "Sarah C Sarver" [record]. She doesn't appear in Eugenius & Alcinda Bright's 1860 household; by 1870 she's living in it, about 13 — and Eugenius left her his estate in 1912 without ever calling her his daughter. Raised in the Bright house, remembered as a Bright, born a Sarver. Why she was placed with them, no record found explains. (Harry and Kathryn appear in no census or marriage record found — they are named only on their daughter's certificate.) - **Bright:** Eugenius Bright + **Alcinda Baker** — her maiden name proven by her own 1849 Monongalia marriage record [record]. Per Eugenius's will, he was buried beside her in the **Everley graveyard** [record: his will]. (An older claim placing her in a private graveyard on Fort Martin Road is unverified — don't state it as fact.) - **Conwell:** Rinaldo Conwell + **Dorcas Harn** — "Harn" settled from Rinaldo's county death register, where the informant reporting his death was Dorcas herself [record]. Behind Rinaldo: **Shepherd Conwell** (1776–1857) + Rebecca (her maiden name unproven) [record]. - **The mother-line, complete:** Suz → Diane → Fran → Ida Ellen Conwell → Susan A. Zearly → **Amelia Darnell**. Amelia's maiden name — the line's last blank — was proven Nov 2 by her son Samuel J. Zearley's 1918 PA death certificate [record]. Five generations of mothers, every one named, every link record-backed. Amelia's own claimed parents remain [open].

2 · Who-is-who, for meeting people cold

- **Eddie & Brenda Cogar** — the guests of honor; 50 years married (Nov 1976). Eddie is Fran's nephew — Juanita's son [family-confirmed by Suz].
- **Erica Cogar** — Eddie & Brenda's **daughter** [family-confirmed — Suz]; party host and RSVP contact (304-282-6579). Her sisters: **Gretchen**, plus one more daughter whose name Suz was still trying to recall on Nov 2 — don't guess it.
- **Suz** — Fran's granddaughter (Diane's daughter); Dan's mother. **Dan** — Fran's great-grandson; Fran was the biggest influence of his life, and he was her caregiver in 2017–18.
- **Diane** — Fran's only child; lives in Stanwood, Michigan (per Fran's obituary).
- Fran was **cremated** [record: her memorial] — if anyone places her at Hopwood Cemetery with the Franks, that's an old assumption, not a record.

3 · Talking points — Fran stories that are safe to tell

- **Nine kids on the Maidsville road.** Fran grew up in Marion and Ida's farmhouse on US 19 with eight siblings; she outlived every one of them.
- **The brother who was two people.** Family trees (ours included) carried Donald *and* Elmore as two brothers born a year apart. One man — the censuses just took turns using his names. Untangling him is how we know the "nine children" count — and Fran's obituary line — is exactly right.
- **Married at 17, a mother at 18, divorced in the newspapers.** Fran married Emmet Van Voorhis in Frederick, Maryland, on 12 Mar 1938. The divorce decree — granted on grounds of "indignities," signed by President Judge H. S. Dumbauld — was covered in the paper, and the family kept the clipping in a scrapbook. (The colorful testimony details are her court allegations as the paper reported them — tell it as her story, which it is.)
- **The golf was still ahead of her.** Three marriages in, Fran became a three-time Uniontown Country Club women's champion, with holes-in-one in 1959 (LaGorce) and 1969 (UCC) [obit].
- **117 Belmont Circle.** Fran's home for some 57 years — and the address where her daughter Diane married George Shrum in September 1961. The house is a family landmark twice over.
- **Suz's middle name.** Suzanne *Whyel* Shrum — Fran's second husband's surname, sitting in the middle of her granddaughter's name. Fran's marriages literally named the next generations.
- **The Sarver story** (if the conversation turns to deep roots): Fran's grandmother grew up in the Bright

household and was always called a Bright — her death certificate says she was born a Sarver, to Harry Sarver and Kathryn Potts. The family she was raised in and the family she was born to were two different families, and both of them claimed her kindly: the Brights left her everything they had.

- **Names you can use Saturday:** greet **Erica** and **Gretchen** by name as Eddie & Brenda's daughters. If the family raises **Alan**, Eddie's late brother, you can acknowledge him accurately — he is family memory (Suz's), not in any record we hold.

4 · Handle with care

- **Eddie's parentage:** family-confirmed by Suz — say that, crediting her. Do **not** claim a document proves it; the paper gap is real (Juanita's 2011 obituary is the candidate document).
- **Brenda's maiden name:** unknown — Suz doesn't know it either. Ask at the party, don't guess.
- **The third Cogar daughter's name:** pending Suz's recall — don't guess.
- **Alan's details** (full name, dates, burial, the adoption question): Suz's testimony only, hedges intact.
- **Fran's burial:** cremated; no cemetery.
- **Alcinda's burial place:** unverified (the will points to the Everley graveyard for Eugenius beside her).
- **Amelia Darnell's parents, Abigail Tibbs's parents, Hezekiah's parents:** open — the records genuinely stop there for now.

Merge note (Nov 2, 2026): this file folds the Suz Q&A addendum's Question-1 results (Eddie family-confirmed, Alan, Erica/Gretchen) into the FINAL packet body. It supersedes `fran-family-packet-FINAL.md` + `fran-family-packet-suz-qa-addendum-2026-11-02.md` *as the one document to carry Saturday. Suz Q&A Questions 2–5 (Fran's Whyel/Coldren marriage dates; George Shrum Jr.; Ira's stepchildren + Vicki; the Sarver/Bright story) were still pending when this was merged — if answers land, they slot into §1/§3 the same way.*